

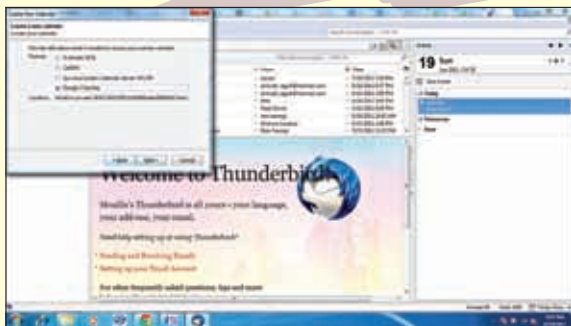
Tweaks for the Professional

We cover some interesting email, scheduling and spreadsheet tweaks that you could benefit from – earning yourself money by saving time!

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Be it commercial products such as Microsoft Office, or open source ones, productivity suites needn't be limited to your office desk. We look at how you could enrich your life by using some productivity tools.



Sync your Google Calendar with your Thunderbird client

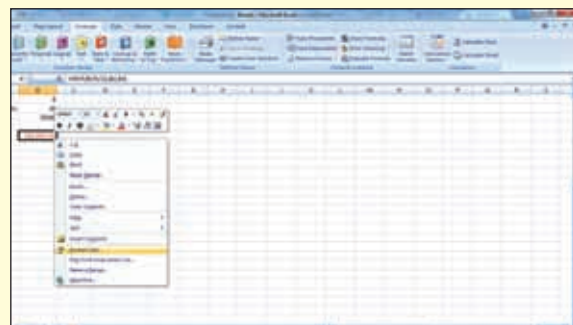
up tab, they should enter their respective mobile numbers and Google would send them a confirmation code. They need to enter this code and their set up will be complete. This is a one-time setting. Now, for each task that you set on the Calendar gets pushed as an email or text message by Google Sync, for free! In fact, the others don't have to login to a computer. We recommend using Google's SMS/email notification to the fullest so that you never miss out on anything important event.

14 LOANS. GULP.

Whether you have a bike, car or home loan, if you have taken the loan at a fixed interest rate, and you have fixed your tenure, then you don't have to rely on EMI calculators. You can build one yourself. You need three quantities: the interest rate (generally specified as per cent per annum), repayment tenure, and the loan amount. Type these in three cells. In the cell where you want to know the monthly instalment, simply type out the following formula:

=PMT(<cell specifying interest%/12>,<cell specifying tenure in months>,<cell specifying loan amount>)

In our case, we had considered an example of a bike that costs Rs. 75000 (cell B3) with a loan tenure of 36 months (cell B2) at 8 per cent per annum (cell B1). You can calculate your



Don't let an agent fool you with instalments

EMI with the following formula:

=PMT(B1%/12,B2,B3)

To understand the way loan instalments are calculated, verify this formula with any online EMI calculator. One example is at bit.ly/emi-calc. If you want to change the currency from the default dollars to Indian Rupees, right-click on the cell, click Format Cells. In Number tab, with Currency selected, click on the Symbol drop down and select Rs. English India.

11 COMMUNICATION AND EMAIL

It's a popular myth that Outlook doesn't have plugins, or doesn't let you chat and be casual, because in addition to commercial and free plugins, you can also augment its functionality by using macros.

Xobni for Outlook

If you use Outlook to manage your email communication, install the Xobni plugin, and you'll have access to Facebook, LinkedIn, Xing, insightful statistics about your nature of interactions with your contacts and much more, without even accessing a browser. If, you don't use an email client, and are wondering which one to choose, we'd recommend Thunderbird. Go to www.getthunderbird.com and download the 9 MB executable for Windows and you'll be up and running in a matter of minutes.

12 CALENDARS AND TO-DO LISTS

Undoubtedly, Outlook provides you with a better Calendar / Organiser to manage your tasks. However, Thunderbird has some useful plugins too. You can use Lightning and Google Calendar for Thunderbird. To install these plugins, simply go to Tools > Add-ons. In the get Add-ons tab, search for Lightning and install the application from the list. Next, install Provider for Google Calendar. Restart Thunderbird once for the changes to take effect.

Now, go to Events and Tasks > Export. Save this ICS file on your computer. In your Gmail/Google Apps accounts, go to Calendars. On the left bar, you would see your Calendar name. Below the name are two options: Add, and Settings. Click on Settings, and import the ICS file from your computer. In your Google Apps/Gmail page, go to Settings and select Calendar Details. Scroll to the bottom of the page. Click on the XML icon next to private address and copy the address.

In Thunderbird, go to File > New > Calendar. Select On the network and pick Google Calendar. Paste the XML link you just copied here and click Next. You may modify the name of your calendar if you choose to, but proceeding works fine too. Enter your Google login details, and you're done.

Now your tasks and events would also stay up-to-date! You can then select SMS notifications from Google as your default settings.

13 AUTO REMINDERS

You can even set a reminder for your family members, and Google would send an email or text message to each person subscribed to the Calendar. To set up each mobile, your family members would have to go to their individual Calendar settings page. On the Mobile Set